

How do customer-related characteristics influence frontline bank employees' boundary spanning behaviors?

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Abstract

Purpose – This study investigated the influence of ambiguous customer expectations and customer demandingness, which reflect hindrance and challenge demands, on the boundary spanning behaviors (BSBs) of frontline bank employees (FBEs) through person-job fit and work engagement. It also examined the moderating effect of customer stewardship between job demands and work engagement.

Design/methodology/approach – Data of 296 FBEs in the retail banking industry in the Republic of Korea were collected through an online survey and analyzed.

Findings – Ambiguous customer expectations acted as hindrance demands and negatively affected FBEs' psychological process. Additionally, customer demandingness positively affected FBEs' psychological process as challenge demands. Moreover, person-job fit and work engagement improved the BSBs of FBEs as a psychological motivation process. Lastly, customer stewardship buffered the negative influence of ambiguous customer expectations on work engagement while strengthening the positive influence of customer demandingness on work engagement.

Originality/value – This study contributes to the marketing literature by presenting customer-related characteristics influencing the BSBs of FBEs and exploring the psychological response processes. First, this study presents empirical evidence that ambiguous customer expectations and customer demandingness play the role of hindrance and challenge demands, respectively. Second, it confirms that customer-related characteristics affect the BSBs of FBEs through psychological processes. Finally, it enriches the authors' understanding of customer stewardship as a job resource by exploring the role of customer stewardship in moderating the relationship between different types of job demands and work engagement.

Keywords Job demands-resources (JD-R) model, Ambiguous customer expectation, Customer demandingness, Employees stewardship toward customers, Boundary-spanning behaviors (BSBs)

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

In a competitive, technologically and systemically changed banking environment, banks have been confronting increased business complexity to obtain better performance (Chatterjee *et al.*, 2022; Yoo and Jung, 2019). Furthermore, the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic has made it even more difficult for banks to generate superior service performance (Olorunsola *et al.*, 2022). On account of these environmental changes, scholars have emphasized that frontline bank employees (FBEs) play a key role in achieving a competitive advantage for banks (Asif and Sargeant, 2000; Yavas and Babakus, 2010). Because the

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customer service quality of banks is determined by close contact between FBEs and their customers (Yoo and Jung, 2019), the roles of FBEs are crucial for banks to be sustainable in times of change, turmoil and crisis (Chatterjee *et al.*, 2022; Lee and Yoo, 2022).

Many scholars have engaged in discussions on the boundary-spanning roles of FBEs over the last several decades due to the importance of FBEs' activities connecting banks and customers (e.g. Abdel-Halim, 1981; Chebat and Kollias, 2000; Green *et al.*, 1983; Lee and Han, 2020; Lievens and Moenaert, 2000; Yoo *et al.*, 2014). In particular, Bettencourt *et al.* (2001) established the concept of boundary-spanning behaviors (BSBs) as specific actions of the boundary-spanning roles, exploring the influences of genuinely excellent service due to the connection between service performance and going beyond one's official role in the designated service area. Moreover, empirical studies have shown that the constructs of BSBs have usually supported our understanding of service performance; consequently, these studies have propounded the positive influence of BSBs on positive customer responses and service performance (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2005; Lee and Han, 2020; Yoo *et al.*, 2014). Accordingly, scholars have identified antecedents to manage BSBs of frontline employees in the services sector. In order to improve employees' BSBs, previous studies have examined the influence of individual-related factors such as role stressors and personality characteristics (e.g. Bettencourt and Brown, 2003; Chien *et al.*, 2021), or have focused on organizational factors such as relational factors within the organization (e.g. Lee and Han, 2020; Yoo, 2013), organizational justice (e.g. Bettencourt *et al.*, 2005) and leadership (e.g. Bayighomog and Arashi, 2019). Despite progress in understanding these antecedents, there are still unresolved questions regarding how customer-related characteristics impact frontline employees' BSB. Further research is needed to enhance and effectively manage frontline employees' BSBs in the banking industry.

Given the critical role customers play in service encounters and their contribution to the company's revenue, it is imperative not to underestimate the significance of customers for frontline employees. Furthermore, Hüttel *et al.* (2019) argued that as employees' opportunity to identify customer need knowledge and suggest customer orientation, the influential power of customer characteristics on employees' perception should be considered. Previous studies have shown that customer-related characteristics affect not only the attitudes of employees related to work but also their job behaviors (Stock and Bednarek, 2014; Yoo and Arnold, 2016). Moreover, because banking services are highly customized, customers not only have heterogeneous characteristics from one another (Hüttel *et al.*, 2019), but also typically engage in a high level of interaction with FBEs before being purchased (Chan *et al.*, 2010). Therefore, customer-related characteristics are particularly important to FBEs in the banking services sector.

As noted by Mikolon *et al.* (2015), banking service, one of the professional services, is generally perceived as very complex by customers. Customers experience reduced cognitive resources as they endeavor to understand the banking service and cognitively depleted customers have difficulty in grasping the service properly (Mikolon *et al.*, 2015). In this context, customers experiencing reduced cognitive resources struggle to comprehend the service, leading to ambiguous expectations and higher customer demandingness. FBEs interact with customers exhibiting these characteristics. Interestingly, ambiguous expectations hinder FBEs' job performance by reducing satisfaction and clear feedback, while customer demandingness requires substantial effort but contributes to personal development and work-related accomplishments (Agnihotri *et al.*, 2017; Dudenhöffer and Dormann, 2015; Jaramillo *et al.*, 2013).

Meanwhile, FBEs require psychological resources to smoothly perform their job roles in response to different customer-related characteristics (i.e. ambiguous customer expectations and customer demandingness) arising from banking services. Identifying the psychological resource factor of FBEs is important because it protects the psychological aspects of FBEs and helps them perform their job roles (Bakker and Demerouti, 2007; Lee and Han, 2020). Thus, the current study proposes customer stewardship as a psychological resource for FBEs and examines the point of interaction between customer-related characteristics and customer

stewardship. Customer stewardship is related to a frontline employee's felt proprietary rights to and ethical responsibility for customers' overall well-being (Schepers *et al.*, 2012) and is driven by intrinsic motivations such as psychological ownership and higher autonomy (Åbländer *et al.*, 2016; Singh and Tiwari, 2020). Therefore, we emphasize the importance of examining BSBs of FBEs in association with customer-related characteristics, as well as the unique role of customer stewardship in a frontline banking service context.

This study aims to achieve the following objectives: (1) empirically examine the impact of ambiguous customer expectations and customer demandingness, as customer-related characteristics in banking services, on frontline employees' boundary-spanning behaviors (BSBs); and (2) investigate the moderating role of customer stewardship on the relationship between customer-related characteristics and the psychological aspects of employees. The study adopts the theoretically extended job demands-resources (JD-R) model as a framework to understand these objectives and related concepts. In this study, ambiguous customer expectations are categorized as hindrance demands and customer demandingness as challenge demands. Moreover, the study explores whether customer stewardship acts as a job resource in the influence of job demands.

2. Theoretical framework and literature review

2.1 Job demands-resources model

The JD-R model explains how two types of job-related characteristics (i.e. job demands and resources) interact in a job situation to influence job motivation and/or stress (Lee and Yoo, 2022). This theoretical perspective focuses on the positive emotions and motivational potential of work-related resources (Bakker and Demerouti, 2007), suggesting that job resources (e.g. autonomy, work support, rewards and job feedback) contribute to true welfare at work. In contrast, various job demands (e.g. increased occupational burden, inappropriate physical job conditions and interplay with customers that generates negative emotions) cause a decrease in employees' energy resources, leading to physical and mental health problems (Yoo *et al.*, 2021).

Job demands refer to the psychological, physical, organizational and social dimensions of work that require physical and/or mental (cognitive and affective) exertion or technique on an ongoing basis and are therefore associated with particular physiological and/or mental costs. Job demand factors are not always adverse, but they may transform into work stressors when excessive exertion is required to satisfy these demands and/or insufficient compensation is provided. However, not only do job resources perform a practical role in attaining job objectives, they reduce the physiological and mental costs incurred by job demands as well. Moreover, job resources encourage individuals to acquire and develop their occupational roles, leading to positive growth. Job resources and demands are usually negatively related (Bakker and Demerouti, 2007; Lee and Yoo, 2022).

Job demands and job resources are assumed to stimulate different psychological processes in the JD-R model (Hakanen *et al.*, 2006): (1) a strain process of exhaustion, wherein excessive job demands decrease individuals' mental and physical resources and may thus cause stress and eventually feeble wellness; and (2) a motivational process wherein job resources reinforce positive job behaviors and outcomes through work engagement (Schaufeli and Bakker, 2004).

Despite the different consequences of job demands and job resources explored in prior studies, not all results have been consistent with these domains of work-related peculiarities (Olafsen and Frølund, 2018). For instance, cognitive demands, time constraints and workloads related to job demands have been previously documented to increase work engagement (Bakker *et al.*, 2005; Schaufeli *et al.*, 2008). In relation to these results, a qualitative classification that divides job demands into hindrance elements and challenge elements has been previously suggested (Crawford *et al.*, 2010; Olafsen and Frølund, 2018; Ventura *et al.*,

2015). Consequently, this leads to three domains of work-related peculiarities within the JD-R model: challenge demands, hindrance demands and job resources (Van Den Broeck *et al.*, 2010).

Challenge demands require work conditions and situations that require energy and effort, but coping with them effectively may lead to learning, development and objective achievement. For example, excessively complicated task conditions may require a large investment of energy, but can simultaneously accelerate the development of skills and abilities. Typically, workload, job complexity and time pressure are included in the challenge demands (Tadić *et al.*, 2015). In contrast, hindrance demands require job conditions and situations that expect energy and effort but do not have development potential. Typically, hindrance demands include role ambiguity, interpersonal conflicts, constraints and job insecurity (LePine *et al.*, 2005; Van Den Broeck *et al.*, 2010). Identifying job demands that are divided into hindrance and challenge elements in job conditions can be beneficial in supervising the mentality, attitude and behaviors of individuals. Thus, it is important to investigate the specific elements of the challenge and hindrance demands.

2.2 Customer-related characteristics in banking services: ambiguous customer expectations and customer demandingness

The perspective of expectations is reflected in a diverse range of fields spanning management studies. It has been argued that unfulfilled expectations are important in sectors such as product and leader performance satisfaction, or job satisfaction (Coye, 2004). In particular, interest in customer expectations in the service sector has consistently surfaced in line with increasing attention to improvements in service quality. In the majority of cases, perceptions of service quality and/or customer satisfaction are considered a function of the difference between the expectations of a customer and their assessment of the real service (Solomon *et al.*, 1985; Walker, 1995; Zeithaml *et al.*, 1993). Coye (2004) notes that customer expectations include the following two principal conceptualizations: (1) the customers' anticipation of what might occur in an imminent transaction or exchange and (2) what the customers ideally want. The first conceptualization represents predictive expectations, which are the subjectively perceived probabilities of the occurrence of future events. The second conceptualization reflects normative expectations that customers wish and/or expect from excellent service employees (Coye, 2004; Miller, 1977; Zeithaml *et al.*, 1990, 1993). Accordingly, if customers' expectations for service are ambiguous, the work roles and behaviors of service employees tend to be disturbed.

Ambiguous customer expectations are related to customers having uncertain and ambiguous requirements, as one of the representative customer-related social stressors arising from interactions between service employees and customers (Dormann and Zapf, 2004; Kim *et al.*, 2012). Furthermore, role ambiguity and uncertainty in goal attainment triggered by ambiguous customer expectations is a representative hindrance demand that causes individuals to use excessive energy for information processing and problem-solving (Crawford *et al.*, 2010). Previous empirical studies have shown that ambiguous customer expectations not only negatively affect psychological aspects such as emotional exhaustion of frontline employees (Dormann and Zapf, 2004), but also result in deterioration in service performance (Kim *et al.*, 2012).

Meanwhile, customer demandingness refers to the level of customers' countless and distinctive demands for obtaining quality, support, satisfaction of special needs and delivery of a product or service (Itani *et al.*, 2020; Li and Calantone, 1998). Over the past decade, customer demand for service organizations and their employees has continuously grown (Agnihotri *et al.*, 2017; Banin *et al.*, 2016; Luu, 2021). Moreover, customers have increasingly diverse demands to enhance their perceived experiences and values (Flint *et al.*, 2011; O'Hern

and Kahle, 2013). The bulge in customer demandingness is triggered by expanded accessibility to information, the sustaining trend of customer empowerment and the galloping competition between service organizations (Luu, 2021; Verbeke *et al.*, 2011), all of which have resulted in more informed customers (Itani *et al.*, 2020). Despite service organizations' efforts to address steadily increasing customer demandingness (Jaramillo *et al.*, 2013; Kumar and Reinartz, 2018), customer demandingness has been treated as a consistent threat due to the lack of understanding of the service organization (Itani *et al.*, 2020). Furthermore, many organizations fail to create customer value and service experiences by ignoring customer demands (Agnihotri *et al.*, 2017; Sandström *et al.*, 2008). Service organizations rely on service employees to respond to customer demands because service employees are not only essential to providing a service experience to customers but also central to the service's capability to modify services to meet customer demands (Gwinner *et al.*, 2005; Sony and Mekoth, 2016). Thus, previous studies have confirmed the effect of customer demandingness on service employees (e.g. Itani *et al.*, 2020; Jaramillo *et al.*, 2013; Jung *et al.*, 2022).

Because customer demandingness utilizes the resources of service employees and can experience higher levels of stress (Agnihotri *et al.*, 2017; Jaramillo *et al.*, 2013), previous studies have implied that customer demandingness belongs to job demands. A high level of customer demandingness puts additional pressure on FBEs in terms of augmented workload and effort, which causes stress (Jaramillo and Mulki, 2008). On the other hand, previous studies have confirmed that customer demandingness play a role in improving the ability and performance of service employees (Banin *et al.*, 2016; Jaramillo *et al.*, 2013). The conflicting roles of customer demandingness imply that it belongs to the challenge demand in that it promotes personal growth and development while requiring psychological energy.

2.3 Customer stewardship

The concept of customer stewardship is derived from stewardship theory, which replaces traditional control systems based on agency theory (Schepers *et al.*, 2012). Agency and stewardship theories are two core theories that are inextricably linked and explain the relationship between an organization's management and its stakeholders (Davis *et al.*, 1997; Tosi *et al.*, 2003). Agency theory assumes that external regulations such as compensation and/or monitoring are required to prohibit management from behaving opportunistically. In contrast, stewardship theory suggests that the interests of managers can be associated with those of stakeholders, such that managers' efforts benefit not only their welfare but others' interests as well (Hernandez, 2008; Schepers *et al.*, 2012). In addition, agency and stewardship theories reveal differences in employee perceptions. Agency theory asserts that employees (agents) will behave according to their own benefit, which may collide with their organization's interests (Van Puyvelde *et al.*, 2012). On the other hand, stewardship theory suggests that employees (stewards) will behave in the best interest of their organization ahead of their own benefit (Hernandez, 2012; Singh and Tiwari, 2020).

Based on stewardship theory, Schepers *et al.* (2012) introduced the concept of customer stewardship in the relationship between service employees and customers. Customer stewardship refers to a service employee's sense of moral responsibility and ownership for their overall well-being (Boateng *et al.*, 2022; Schepers *et al.*, 2012). For the concept of customer stewardship, responsibility and psychological ownership are key motives for aligning the interests of service employees and customers (Block, 1996; Davis *et al.*, 1997). Service employees who feel responsible for their customers perform role duties in return for awareness from customers and the intensification of their occupational beliefs (Hernandez, 2012). Job-related activities that fail to improve customer well-being and are inconsistent with one's beliefs are rectified through self-regulation (Schepers *et al.*, 2012; Tosi *et al.*, 2003).

Psychological ownership also leads service employees to perceive customer interests as their own. Service employees are motivated to prevent exposure to excessive loss or damage when they pursue their own interests (Hernandez, 2008; Pierce *et al.*, 2001).

Previous studies related to customer stewardship indicate that customer stewardship can share conceptual territory with customer orientation and therefore embrace the concept of service to and enhancement of customers (Schepers *et al.*, 2012). However, there are two distinct differences between customer stewardship and orientation. The first difference stems from the source of the control of work behavior. Customer orientation focuses on the control of performance perspectives because it seeks to satisfy customer needs by aiming to achieve performance for service employees and organizations (Franke and Park, 2006; Jaramillo and Grisaffe, 2009; Jaramillo *et al.*, 2009). In contrast, customer stewardship emphasizes the psychological control of service employees because it not only recognizes replying to customer needs as an occupational obligation within a formal control system, but considers customer well-being as a moral restriction within an informal control system as well (Davis *et al.*, 1997; Schepers *et al.*, 2012). The second difference arises from the distinction between the areas of concern for customers. Customer orientation is a comparatively steady, personal surface characteristic that affects job attitudes and behaviors by focusing on satisfying customer needs (Flaherty *et al.*, 2009; Licata *et al.*, 2003). By contrast, customer stewardship is a more embracing construct that concentrates on the overall well-being of customers rather than customer needs (Schepers *et al.*, 2012).

Similar to the common context of stewardship literature, which values pursuing others' interests over self-interests (Block, 1996; Davis *et al.*, 1997), customer stewardship allows service employees to form a fundamental belief that puts customer interests ahead of their own. This discussion does not imply that customer stewardship has no personal interest in service employees. Rather, it implies that serving customer interests is eventually linked to the attainment of service employees' personal interests (Singh and Tiwari, 2020). Customer stewardship, in this sense, is more willing to conduct actions that prioritize the interests of customers, even in situations where customer interest and self-interest conflict (Davis *et al.*, 1997; Singh and Tiwari, 2020). Service employees, who regard themselves as holding stewardship roles, are responsible for customers (Caldwell *et al.*, 2008; De Ruyter *et al.*, 2009). They are perceived as partners for customers and enjoy reputational enhancement, reciprocity and autonomy (Block, 1996; Van Puyvelde *et al.*, 2012). In addition, stewardship has needs and values that are admired and valued as ends in themselves (Caldwell and Karri, 2005). Customer stewardship creates intrinsic forms of motivation for service employees (Abländer *et al.*, 2016; Singh and Tiwari, 2020). Based on this discussion, we propose that customer stewardship is a job resource for FBEs.

2.4 Psychological aspects of FBEs on customer-related characteristics: person-job fit and work engagement

Person-environment fit signifies the conformance between individuals and particular categories of work environments (Bretz and Judge, 1994) and has received a lot of interest from both practitioners and scholars interested in interpreting the attitudes and behaviors of employees (Bui *et al.*, 2017; Chuang and Sackett, 2005). The concept of person-environment fit is broad (Kristof-Brown *et al.*, 2005), and previous studies have reflected it through various types of fits associated with the work environment, such as tasks (Wronska *et al.*, 2019), groups (Seong and Kristof-Brown, 2012), supervisors (Van Vianen *et al.*, 2011) and customers (Yoo, 2016). Among these, person-job fit is a key element that represents person-environment fit (Lam *et al.*, 2018; Lee and Yoo, 2022). Person-environment fit is divided into two categories: supplementary fit and complementary fit (Bui *et al.*, 2017). Supplementary fit refers to possessing similar characteristics between individuals and their work environment, whereas

complementary fit means that individuals and their work environment have different features, but need each other to form the entirety or replenish what is missing (Boon *et al.*, 2011; Bui *et al.*, 2017; Kristof-Brown, 1996). Person-job fit is included in the complementary fit for the particular qualifications demanded in terms of jobs and individuals (Edwards, 1991; Kristof-Brown *et al.*, 2005). Specifically, person-job fit comprises two types of fit that represent specific characteristics (Tims *et al.*, 2016). The fit of the first characteristic is demand-ability fit, which is related to the ability, expertise and techniques of service employees to satisfy job requirements. From an occupational perspective, person-job fit improves when service employees have the qualifications and techniques to conduct their work. The fit of the second characteristic is the needs-supplies fit, which means that the job satisfies service employees' preferences and needs. In terms of employees, person-job fit increases when service employees' needs, such as pay, social relationships and self-actualization, are fulfilled (Lee and Yoo, 2022; Tims *et al.*, 2016). While these types of fit were dealt with separately in earlier studies (Cable and DeRue, 2002), they have been integrated into a single and overall concept of person-job fit in recent studies (Yoo, 2013). In addition, previous studies mention that person-job fit belongs to the cognitive dimension in the psychological aspects of an individual (Lee and Yoo, 2022).

Meanwhile, work engagement refers to a high standard of devotion and a powerful concentration of work conjoined with a condition of positive and affective motivation (Schaufeli and Bakker, 2010) and represents the emotional domain in terms of psychological aspects (Lee and Yoo, 2022). Work engagement is a core aspect of employees' psychological condition, as described in the J-DR model. The psychological motivation process in the JD-R model appears when employees acquire resources for job fulfillment (Bakker and Demerouti, 2007), and work engagement is a mental response that occurs in the psychological motivation process for job resources (Bakker *et al.*, 2014). Work engagement comprises three characteristic elements: vigor, dedication and absorption (Bakker and Demerouti, 2008; Schaufeli and Bakker, 2004). Vigor is associated with the condition wherein a high standard of energy persists even after employees face difficulties. Dedication refers to participation in a job while experiencing a sense of challenge, significance and inspiration. Absorption is related to the condition wherein an individual is too focused on the task of identifying with the task (Schaufeli *et al.*, 2002). Work engagement is the basis for achieving high standards of organizational performance and is encouraged to form a high level of work engagement in contemporary organizations (Bakker and Demerouti, 2007; Lee and Yoo, 2022).

2.5 Boundary-spanning behaviors

Boundary-spanning employees oscillate between the organization's external and/or internal borders in the fulfillment of their occupational roles (Yoo, 2013). Thus, boundary-spanning employees interact not just with internal members but with external customers too (Adams, 1976). BSBs refer to frontline employees' activities that originate from their occupational roles as boundary spanners for their organization (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2001; Chebat and Kollias, 2000).

Previous marketing and management studies have stated that frontline employees perform three fundamental boundary-spanning roles (Bettencourt and Brown, 2003; Bettencourt *et al.*, 2001; Yoo *et al.*, 2014). The first role is to achieve high customer service quality perceptions and satisfaction through frontline employees' activities, such as politeness, personal interest and response and fulfillment of guarantees (Parasuraman *et al.*, 1988). The second role is to improve the image and legitimacy of the service organization by representing it to external stakeholders and supporting products and services (Lee and Han, 2020). The third role is to provide various opportunities to exchange intelligence internally about changing customer requirements and feasible developments in goods and

service offerings (Yoo, 2013). Based on these roles, Bettencourt *et al.* (2001) suggested three categories of BSBs that customer-contact workers may conduct related to connecting the organization to its practical customers.

- (1) Service delivery: Responding to customers sincerely, receptively, pliantly and politely.
- (2) External representation: Vocal endorsements to external stakeholders of the firm's impression, goods and service offering.
- (3) Internal influence: Taking personal leadership in interactions with the organization and internal members to enhance service offering by oneself, internal members and the organization.

Like frontline employees in other service industries, FBEs are boundary spanners that directly deliver financial services to customers, represent banks to customers and communicate acquired customer needs to banks (Lee and Han, 2020). The essential work role of FBEs is that of BSBs. Thus, it is necessary to manage the BSBs of FBEs to improve their work performance.

3. Hypotheses development

3.1 Ambiguous customer expectations, person-job fit and work engagement

Ambiguous customer expectations can negatively affect the psychological aspects of FBEs, because they cause role ambiguity and uncertainty in goal attainment (Dudenhöffer and Dormann, 2015). If customers' expectations of service are not accurately known, FBEs do not have a clear understanding of their role in the service process. Because service providers' responses and attitudes toward customers in service situations have a significant influence on customers' perceptions of service (Hartline and Ferrell, 1996), it is the core roles of FBEs to make customers highly aware of service quality (Lee and Yoo, 2022). A key way to improve service quality is to bridge the gap between customers' expectations for service and FBEs' understanding of such expectations (Luk and Layton, 2002). Ambiguous customer expectations interfere with the role behavior of FBEs because of ambiguous feedback, making it difficult to satisfy customer expectations (Dudenhöffer and Dormann, 2015). On the other hand, FBEs may revise the service roles or the process based on their understanding of what is expected by customers (Luk and Layton, 2002). Therefore, the increased understanding of customer expectations influences the job role performance of FBEs (Schepers and van der Borgh, 2020). Eventually, due to ambiguous customer expectations, FBEs may believe that they and their occupations do not match each other because they judge their knowledge and skills to be insufficient to provide services to solve customer problems. Meanwhile, if the achievement of occupational goals is uncertain, then FBEs cannot satisfy an individual's needs to be met through the job. Uncertainty of goal attainment due to ambiguous customer expectations leads FBEs to expect that they will not achieve the desired levels of pay or self-realization through their jobs. In general, pay-for-performance systems that connect employees' salary levels with their previous or future job performance and incentives based on individual job performance are used as important organizations' compensation strategy (Gerhart and Fang, 2014; Gerhart and Rynes, 2003; Gerhart *et al.*, 2009; He *et al.*, 2021; Lee *et al.*, 2020). These compensation systems serve as motivation for employees to achieve better performance (He *et al.*, 2021). In addition, the need for achievement has been recognized as an essential psychological need for individuals (Albrecht, 2015; Schriesheim and Schriesheim, 1980), whereas ambiguous customer expectations hinder the occupational achievement of FBEs. Thus, ambiguous customer expectations are perceived as a hindrance demand that obstructs the psychological satisfaction of FBEs.

In summary, we suggest that ambiguous customer expectations are hindrance demands and are negatively related to both person-job fit and work engagement, which are the cognitive and emotional psychological aspects of FBEs.

H1. Ambiguous customer expectations have a negative influence on person-job fit.

H2. Ambiguous customer expectations have a negative influence on work engagement.

3.2 Customer demandingness, person-job fit and work engagement

Because customer demandingness utilizes the resources of service employees and can experience higher levels of stress (Agnihotri *et al.*, 2017; Jaramillo *et al.*, 2013), previous studies have implied that customer demandingness belongs to job demands. A high level of customer demandingness puts additional pressure on FBEs in terms of augmented workload and effort, which causes stress (Jaramillo and Mulki, 2008). However, customer demandingness has been confirmed to play a role in improving the ability and performance of service employees (Banin *et al.*, 2016; Jaramillo *et al.*, 2013). A high level of customer demandingness encourages FBEs to learn more about their customers and develop customized solutions for customer problems (Wang and Netemeyer, 2004). Furthermore, customer demandingness augments a new set of problem-solving and value-providing abilities, such as enhanced improvisation, creativity and FBEs' efforts (working smart and hard) in service situations, to FBEs' traditional portfolios (Itani *et al.*, 2020; Luu, 2021). Regarding the psychological aspect of FBEs, customer demandingness is accepted as a challenging task, and the growth needs of FBEs can be satisfied by solving high levels of customer demandingness through the application of new knowledge and skills (Agnihotri *et al.*, 2017). We suggest that customer demandingness is a challenge that enhances job competency and motivation.

H3. Customer demandingness has a positive influence on person-job fit.

H4. Customer demandingness has a positive influence on work engagement.

3.3 Person-job fit and work engagement

When service employees perceive that their abilities match their job requirements, they maintain positive emotions and attitudes, feel happiness and passionately engage in their jobs (Lam *et al.*, 2018). Larsen and McKibban (2008) confirmed that individuals wishing what they possess and possessing what they wish increase their psychological well-being, such as happiness. In the occupational context, demands-abilities fit is associated with individuals wishing what they possess, and needs-supplies fit is associated with individuals possessing what they wish (Lee and Yoo, 2022). In the same context, the extant literature has confirmed that person-job fit has positive effects on service employees (Babakus *et al.*, 2010; Lam *et al.*, 2018; Yoo, 2013). Lee and Yoo (2022) demonstrated that person-job fit, which belongs to the cognitive aspect, has a positive influence on the emotional aspect and leads to a motivational process. Based on these discussions, we suggest the following hypothesis:

H5. Person-job fit has a positive influence on work engagement.

3.4 Work engagement and boundary-spanning behaviors

Previous studies related to the JD-R model show that work engagement leads to high outcomes for individuals and organizations because it improves the fulfillment of in- and extra-roles (Bakker and Demerouti, 2008; Bakker *et al.*, 2004; Gierveld and Bakker, 2005; Salanova *et al.*, 2005; Xanthopoulou *et al.*, 2007). Therefore, it can be predicted that FBEs with a high level of work engagement will make efforts to perform their job roles. FBEs who are strongly motivated obtain satisfaction from job achievement and thus work harder to excel

(Staw, 1977; Yoo *et al.*, 2014). In addition, work engagement increases the organizational citizenship behavior of FBEs, leading to altruistic behavior by prioritizing the organization (Yoo *et al.*, 2021). Since FBEs evaluate performing tasks that are helpful to customers and colleagues as an important job characteristic, they may be more concerned about the outcomes of their work enforcement, as well as the work achievement of colleagues and organizational success. Yoo *et al.* (2014) confirmed that FBEs' psychological motivation has a positive effect on the three types of BSBs, which are their occupational roles. Thus, the following hypotheses are proposed:

- H6. Work engagement has a positive influence on service delivery.
- H7. Work engagement has a positive influence on external representation.
- H8. Work engagement has a positive influence on internal influence.

3.5 Moderating role of customer stewardship

We propose that customer stewardship buffers the negative effect of customer-related hindrance demands on work engagement. Hindrance demands, such as ambiguous customer expectations, accumulate stress and interfere with work roles and behaviors in reaching work performance (Dudenhöffer and Dormann, 2015; Kim *et al.*, 2012). Even if FBEs experience high hindrance demands, having access to sufficient job resources may buffer the negative effects of hindrance demands because job resources increase the willingness to devote effort to work (Meijman and Mulder, 1998; Tadić *et al.*, 2015). For example, customer stewardship can provide the energy required for customers' ambiguous expectations through the motivation to pursue their interests. Moreover, as customer stewardship leads FBEs to focus more on the welfare of their customers, they may be less concerned with the uncertainty of goal achievement because of ambiguous customer expectations. This suggests that customer stewardship moderates the relationship between ambiguous customer expectations and work engagement. Meanwhile, we argue that customer stewardship boosts the positive effect of customer-related challenge demands on work engagement. When faced with complex or challenging problems at work, access to sufficient job resources improves one's job competency and the prospect that one's work effort will lead to positive outcomes. Thus, challenge demands have the highest motivational potential when combined with job resources (Tadić *et al.*, 2015; Widmer *et al.*, 2012). This can improve work engagement. In the context of FBEs, customer demand as a challenge demand leads to engagement in work because of the ability to develop customized solutions. At the same time, customer stewardship stimulates FBEs' work engagement by an immersion in customer interests. Accordingly, we propose the following hypotheses:

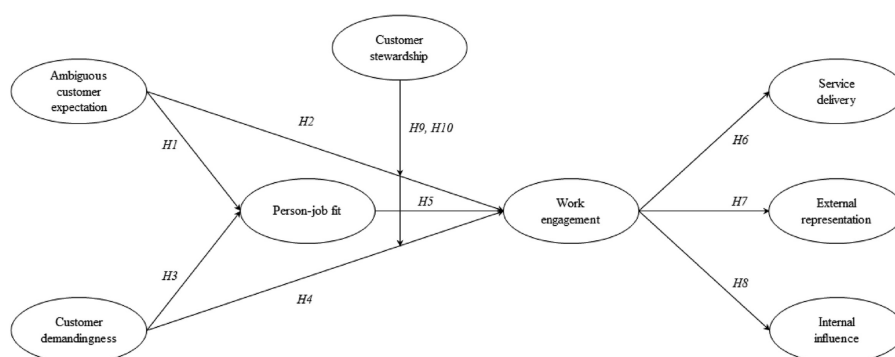
- H9. The negative influence of ambiguous customer expectations on work engagement will be weaker when customer stewardship is high.
- H10. The positive influence of customer demandingness on work engagement will be stronger when customer stewardship is high.

Based on the proposed research hypotheses, we established the research model shown in Figure 1.

4. Method

4.1 Samples and procedure

We collected data from FBEs in the retail banking industry in the Republic of Korea, using the online service of a specialized survey institution. This specialized survey institution enrolls

Figure 1.
Research model

Source(s): Author's own creation

people who wish to spontaneously engage in surveys and does not limit the affiliated organizations or districts of participants. The survey institution has the largest number of participants as an online panel in Korea, and it encourages participants to be involved in surveys by providing points that can be swapped for money. The URL to access the online survey was selectively sent to only bank employees among the panel participants, and participants were allowed to conduct the survey through a mobile device or personal computer. The participants were also asked to proceed with a two-step process before conducting the full-scale survey. In the first step, participants were given a list of occupations and were asked to choose their current occupation. At this stage, individuals who were not currently bank employees were excluded from the survey. In the second step, the participants were presented with a list of duties and asked to select their principal duties. At this stage, only bank employees who sold financial products and/or provided financial services to customers were selected to conduct the final survey. The URL to access the survey was sent to 450 participants over 3 weeks, and data was collected from 296 surveys completed (response rate 65.78%).

Of 296 participants, 173 (58.4%) were men and 123 (41.6%) were women. The majority of participants were in their 30s (101; 34.1%), followed by those in their 40s (91; 30.7%), 20s (64; 21.6%) and 50s or older (40; 13.5%). The highest number of participants had graduated from university (202; 68.2%), followed by those who graduated from high school (73; 24.7%), those either attending or graduated from graduate school (11; 3.7%) and those attending university (10; 3.4%). In addition, the majority had a work experience of less than 3 years (83; 28.0%), followed by those with more than 3 years and less than 6 years (69; 23.3%), more than 12 years (61; 20.6%), more than 6 years and less than 9 years (42; 14.2%), and more than 9 years and less than 12 years (41; 13.9%). Regarding monthly average income, 94 participants (31.8%) reported earning less than 2 million Korean won (KRW; 1 million KRW is about USD 750), 99 (33.4%) reported more than 2 million KRW and less than 3 million KRW, 49 (16.6%) reported more than 3 million KRW and less than 4 million KRW, 28 (9.5%) reported more than 4 million KRW and less than 5 million KRW, and 26 (8.8%) reported earning more than 5 million KRW.

4.2 Measurement of variables

All measurement scales used in this study were developed in English and we translated them into Korean. During the translation process, the translated version of the measurement items was evaluated by two experts who can speak both English and Korean. In addition,

we performed the back-translation process to confirm that the items translated into Korean have the same meaning as the original version. All measurement scales are shown in [Table 1](#).

To measure ambiguous customer expectations, three measurement items from [Dormann and Zapf \(2004\)](#) were selected. Ambiguous customer expectations reflect the degree of uncertain and ambiguous demands perceived by FBEs.

To assess customer demandingness, four scale measures from [Wang and Netemeyer \(2002\)](#) were selected. The items were originally used by [Li and Calantone \(1998\)](#) to evaluate the level of quality, reliability, service and requirements demanded by the customer.

To evaluate person-job fit, four items utilized in the study of [Yoo \(2013\)](#) were used. This measure reflects a single concept that encompasses demands-abilities fit and needs-supplies fit.

In this study, nine scale measures (Utrecht Work Engagement Scale-9; UWES-9) proposed by [Schaufeli et al. \(2006\)](#) were used to measure work engagement. The scale has three aspects: composing vigor, dedication and absorption.

Customer stewardship measured with four items adapted from [Schepers et al. \(2012\)](#). This measure reflects the sense of moral responsibility and ownership of the FBEs for the customers' overall welfare.

To measure the BSBs of FBEs, twelve scale measures from [Bettencourt et al. \(2005\)](#) were used. Specifically, service delivery was measured using four items that reflected the manner of providing the desired level of service to customers. External representation also used four items to measure the behavior of promoting financial products and services, and the image of the organization outside of their company. Finally, internal influence was measured using four items that reflect the degree to which FBEs communicate with colleagues and organizations to enhance service delivery from themselves, internal members and organizations.

All items in this study were assessed on a 5-point scale ranging from "strongly disagree" to "strongly agree".

5. Analysis results

5.1 Measurement model analysis

Using covariance-based structural equation modeling (CB-SEM, Amos21), measurements and the hypothesized model were identified. Prior to testing the hypotheses, we identified the constructs' reliability and validity in the measurement model. The measurement model comprised 36 reflective indicators and 8 correlated latent factors, equivalent to the 8 constructs shown in [Figure 1](#). The reliability of the constructs was estimated through an internal consistency method using Cronbach's α coefficient ([Nunnally, 1978](#)). All Cronbach's α coefficients for the constructs were confirmed to be greater than 0.7, which was regarded as satisfactory. We also performed confirmatory factor analysis (CFA). Composite reliability (CR) was checked to measure reliability at model level, and average variance extracted (AVE) was used to evaluate convergent validity. As a result of conducting CFA, the fit of measurement model was shown as $\chi^2 = 1085.86$ ($df = 566, p < 0.01$), CFI = 0.92, TLI = 0.91, IFI = 0.92, RMR = 0.03 and RMSEA = 0.06. Moreover, all observed variable loadings were statistically significant ($p < 0.01$), and the CR and AVE scores of each latent construct satisfied the criteria proposed by [Hair et al. \(2010\)](#). [Table 1](#) presents the CFA results.

To assess discriminant validity, correlations between latent constructs and the square root value of AVE were compared ([Fornell and Larcker, 1981](#)). We verified that the correlations between the constructs were lower than the square root value of AVE (see [Table 2](#)). In addition, heterotrait-monotrait (HTMT) criterion was examined to confirm discriminant validity. HTMT criterion is considered to be the new standard for testing discriminant validity ([Henseler et al., 2015](#); [Voorhees et al., 2016](#)). The results of HTMT test

Construct	Items	λ^a	α	CR ^b	AVE ^c
Ambiguous customer expectation	1. Customers' wishes are often contradictory 2. It is difficult to make arrangements with customers 3. Customers' instructions can complicate our work	0.62 0.93 0.80	0.75	0.83	0.63
Customer demandingness	1. The clients I serve are demanding in regard to product/service quality and reliability 2. My clients have high expectations for service and support 3. My clients require a perfect fit between their needs and our product/service offering 4. My clients expect me to deliver the highest levels of product and service quality	0.84 0.88 0.88 0.90	0.90	0.93	0.76
Person-job fit	1. To what extent is the job a good match for you? 2. To what extent does the job fulfill your needs? 3. To what extent do your knowledge, skills, and abilities match the requirement of the job? 4. To what extent does the job enable you to do the kind of work you want to do?	0.83 0.83 0.83 0.79	0.84	0.89	0.68
Work engagement	1. At work, I feel very energetic 2. At my job, I feel strong and vigorous 3. When I get up in the morning, I feel like going to work 4. I am enthusiastic about my job 5. My job inspires me 6. I am proud of the work that I do 7. I feel happy when I am working intensely 8. I am immersed in my work 9. I get carried away when I am working	0.70 0.76 0.67 0.80 0.79 0.80 0.74 0.72 0.60	0.89	0.91	0.54
Service delivery	1. I follow up in a timely manner to customer requests and problems 2. Regardless of circumstances, I am exceptionally courteous and respectful to customers 3. I follow through in a conscientious manner on promises to customers 4. I take time to understand customer needs (on an individual basis)	0.71 0.83 0.88 0.81	0.83	0.88	0.66
External representation	1. I tell outsiders this is a great place to work 2. I generate favorable goodwill for my company 3. I say good things about my company to others 4. I encourage others to use my company's products and services	0.81 0.88 0.87 0.83	0.87	0.91	0.72
Internal influence	1. I make constructive suggestions for sale and service improvement 2. I contribute many ideas for customer promotions and communications 3. I share creative solutions to customer problems with other salespeople 4. I encourage co-workers to contribute ideas and suggestions for sale and service improvement	0.84 0.87 0.84 0.85	0.87	0.91	0.73
Customer stewardship	1. I feel a sense of responsibility for the customer 2. I sense that the customers I serve are my customers 3. I feel a sense of ownership of the customer's problems 4. I feel responsible for customer welfare	0.84 0.85 0.85 0.79	0.85	0.90	0.69

Note(s): $\chi^2 = 1085.86$ (df = 566, $p = 0.00$), CFI = 0.92, TLI = 0.91, IFI = 0.92, RMR = 0.03, RMSEA = 0.06

^aAll factor loadings are significant ($p < 0.01$); ^bCR = composite reliability; ^cAVE = average variance extracted

Source(s): Authors' own creation

Table 1.
Measurement items
and results of CFA

IJBM 41,7		1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
		1. ACE	0.79						
1958		2. Customer demandingness	0.60**	0.87					
		3. P-J fit	-0.13	0.09	0.82				
		4. Work engagement	-0.01	0.29**	0.63**	0.73			
		5. Service delivery	0.20**	0.54**	0.34**	0.51**	0.81		
		6. External representation	-0.02	0.32**	0.58**	0.71**	0.61**	0.85	
		7. Internal influence	0.07	0.27**	0.51**	0.67**	0.47**	0.64**	0.85
		8. Customer stewardship	0.22**	0.54**	0.41**	0.61**	0.66**	0.63**	0.53**
		Mean	3.68	3.94	3.14	3.32	3.74	3.45	3.36
		SD	0.68	0.65	0.72	0.56	0.56	0.69	0.65
			0.62						0.62
Table 2.		Note(s): The number in the diagonal is the square root of the AVE; ACE = ambiguous customer expectation							
Measurements of		** $p < 0.01$							
correlations and		Source(s): Authors' own creation							
discriminant validity									

confirmed that the values between latent constructs were lower than a threshold of 0.85, indicating that discriminant validity was obtained (Clark and Watson, 1995; Kline, 2011). Table 3 shows the results of HTMT criterion. Overall, measurement model suggests that the proposed constructs are reliable and valid.

5.2 Common method variance

Previous studies have argued that the common method variance (CMV) may lead to critical bias when performing behavioral research using single-source surveys (Rodríguez-Pinto et al., 2011). Podsakoff et al. (2003) suggested statistical remedies to solve the potential problem caused by CMV. We implemented Harman's single-factor test, a statistical remedy, using a confirmatory factor-analytic approach. The single-factor model ($\chi^2 = 3273.11$ [$df = 594, p < 0.01$], CFI = 0.56, TLI = 0.54, IFI = 0.56, RMR = 0.08, RMSEA = 0.12) showed a worse fit than the measurement model proposed in this study. Consequently, we confirmed that CMV was unlikely to distort the results.

5.3 Hypotheses testing

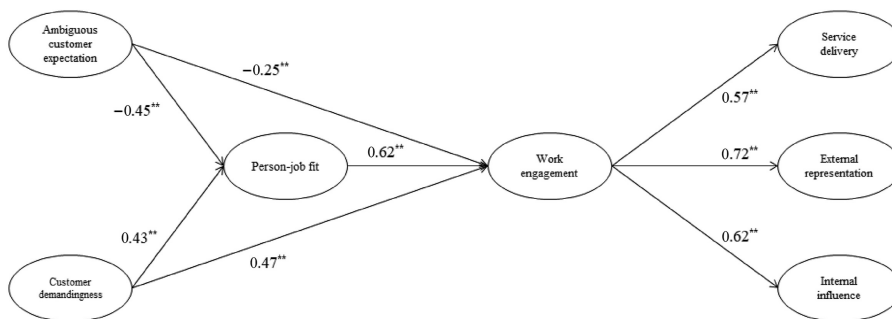
To test the direct relationships among the constructs in the research model, we used structural equation modeling (SEM). The overall fit of the research model was $\chi^2 = 975.44$ ($df = 455, p < 0.01$), CFI = 0.90, TLI = 0.89, IFI = 0.90, RMR = 0.04 and RMSEA = 0.06, which are generally acceptable. We predicted, through H1 and H2, that ambiguous customer

		1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
		1. ACE							
Table 3.		2. Customer demandingness	0.75						
		3. P-J fit	0.16	0.12					
		4. Work engagement	0.11	0.31	0.68				
		5. Service delivery	0.23	0.56	0.34	0.52			
		6. External representation	0.08	0.32	0.59	0.79	0.60		
		7. Internal influence	0.07	0.28	0.50	0.71	0.48	0.69	
		8. Customer stewardship	0.21	0.54	0.43	0.65	0.72	0.65	0.56
Table 3.		Note(s): ACE = ambiguous customer expectation							
Results of heterotrait–		Source(s): Authors' own creation							
monotrait (HTMT)									
criterion									

expectations would have a negative influence on FBEs' person-job fit and work engagement. The results indicated that ambiguous customer expectations had a negative influence on person-job fit ($\beta = -0.45, p < 0.01$) and a negative effect on work engagement ($\beta = -0.25, p < 0.01$). Thus, H1 and H2 were supported. We also predicted, through H3 and H4, that customer demandingness would have a positive influence on FBEs' person-job fit and work engagement. The results show that customer demandingness has a positive influence on an FBEs' person-job fit ($\beta = 0.43, p < 0.01$). The effect of customer demandingness on work engagement is also positive and significant ($\beta = 0.47, p < 0.01$). Thus, H3 and H4 were supported. H5 predicted that person-job fit would have a positive effect on work engagement, and the analysis revealed that person-job fit positively influenced work engagement ($\beta = 0.62, p < 0.01$). Thus, H5 was accepted as well. Finally, we predicted through H6, H7 and H8 that FBEs' work engagement would have a positive effect on their BSBs. The results showed that work engagement has positive effects on service delivery ($\beta = 0.57, p < 0.01$), external representation ($\beta = 0.72, p < 0.01$) and internal influence behavior ($\beta = 0.62, p < 0.01$), which are factors of BSBs. Thus, H6, H7 and H8 were all supported. Figure 2 shows the results of the hypothesis testing.

5.4 Moderating effects of customer stewardship

We used the PROCESS macro, based on the bootstrapping method suggested by Hayes (2013), to test the moderating effects of customer stewardship on the relationships between customer-related characteristics, which reflect hindrance and challenge demands, and work engagement. Because customer-related characteristics were established to influence work engagement through person-job fit in our research model, we used the PROCESS macro (conditional process analysis) model 5 to confirm the interaction effect of customer stewardship and the indirect effect of person-job fit. In order to perform the analysis, bootstrap resamples were set to 5,000 and the bootstrap confidence intervals was set to 95%. Moreover, we inserted customer-related characteristics (i.e. ambiguous customer expectations and customer demandingness) as *X*, work engagement as *Y*, person-job fit as *M* and customer stewardship as *W* (Hayes, 2013). We set demographic variables as control variables. Previous studies have suggested that demographic factors such as gender, age, work experience and education can affect frontline employees (Lee and Yoo, 2022; Levy and Sharma, 1994; Franke and Park, 2006). Therefore, we used demographic factors of FBEs as control variables to rule out the possibility that these would influence the relationship between variables. The PROCESS macro model 5 provides results in two steps.



Note(s): $^{**}p < 0.01$, ($\chi^2 = 975.44$, $df = 455$, $p = 0.00$, $CFI = 0.90$, $TLI = 0.89$, $IFI = 0.90$, $RMR = 0.04$, $RMSEA = 0.06$)

Source(s): Author's own creation

Figure 2.
Results of hypotheses

The PROCESS macro procedure was conducted to confirm the moderating effect of customer stewardship between ambiguous customer expectations and work engagement. In the first step, the influences of ambiguous customer expectations and control variables on person-job fit were identified. Ambiguous customer expectations had a negatively significant effect on person-job fit (coeff = -0.1542 , CI = $[-0.2692, -0.0392]$). Among the control variables, gender (coeff = -0.1719 , CI = $[-0.3396, -0.0042]$), age (coeff = -0.1695 , CI = $[-0.2661, -0.0729]$) and income (coeff = 0.1718 , CI = $[0.0938, 0.2497]$) were significantly related to person-job fit. However, educational background (coeff = 0.0206 , CI = $[-0.0684, 0.1095]$) and work experience (coeff = 0.0017 , CI = $[-0.0632, 0.0667]$) were not significantly related to person-job fit.

In the second step, the influences of ambiguous customer expectations, person-job fit, customer stewardship, the interaction effect (ambiguous customer expectations $\times$ customer stewardship) and control variables on work engagement were identified. Ambiguous customer expectations had a negatively significant effect on work engagement (coeff = -0.6013 , CI = $[-0.9700, -0.2326]$), while person-job fit had a positively significant effect on work engagement (coeff = 0.3085 , CI = $[0.2340, 0.3830]$). The moderating effect of customer stewardship on the relationship between ambiguous customer expectations and work engagement show a significant interaction effect (coeff = 0.1542 , CI = $[0.0576, 0.2509]$). Among the control variables, income (coeff = 0.0791 , CI = $[0.0315, 0.1266]$) was significantly related to work engagement. However, gender (coeff = 0.0333 , CI = $[-0.0674, 0.1339]$), age (coeff = -0.0185 , CI = $[-0.0781, 0.0410]$), educational background (coeff = -0.0278 , CI = $[-0.0810, 0.0254]$) and work experience (coeff = -0.0237 , CI = $[-0.0620, 0.0147]$) were not significantly related to work engagement. In addition, the conditional direct effect of ambiguous customer expectations on work engagement was significant only at the -1 SD level (coeff = -0.1190 , CI = $[-0.2119, -0.0261]$) and person-job fit mediated the relationship between ambiguous customer expectations and work engagement (coeff = -0.0476 , CI = $[-0.0891, -0.0084]$). Table 4 shows the results of the PROCESS macro model 5 that analyzed the moderating effect of customer stewardship between ambiguous customer expectation and work engagement.

In addition, we conducted the PROCESS macro procedure to confirm the moderating effect of customer stewardship between customer demandingness and work engagement. In the first step, the influences of customer demandingness and control variables on person-job fit were identified. Customer demandingness had a positively significant effect on person-job fit (coeff = 0.0913 , CI = $[0.0010, 0.1815]$). Among the control variables, gender (coeff = -0.2071 , CI = $[-0.3768, -0.0373]$), age (coeff = -0.1514 , CI = $[-0.2488, -0.0541]$) and income (coeff = 0.1543 , CI = $[0.0745, 0.2341]$) were significantly related to person-job fit. However, educational background (coeff = 0.0166 , CI = $[-0.0732, 0.1065]$) and work experience (coeff = 0.0098 , CI = $[-0.0559, 0.0756]$) were not significantly related to person-job fit.

In the second step, the influences of customer demandingness, person-job fit, customer stewardship, the interaction effect (customer demandingness $\times$ customer stewardship) and control variables on work engagement were identified. Customer demandingness (coeff = 0.2985 , CI = $[0.1879, 0.3091]$) and person-job fit (coeff = 0.3188 , CI = $[0.2461, 0.3916]$) had significant effects on work engagement. The moderating effect of customer stewardship on the relationship between customer demandingness and work engagement show a significant interaction effect (coeff = 0.1797 , CI = $[0.0780, 0.2815]$). Among the control variables, income (coeff = 0.0656 , CI = $[0.0257, 0.1055]$) was significantly related to work engagement. However, gender (coeff = 0.0162 , CI = $[-0.0680, 0.1004]$), age (coeff = -0.0025 , CI = $[-0.0518, 0.0468]$), educational background (coeff = -0.0314 , CI = $[-0.0755, 0.0127]$) and work experience (coeff = -0.0180 , CI = $[-0.0501, 0.0142]$) were not significantly related to work engagement. In addition, the conditional direct effect of customer demandingness on

	<i>b</i>	(Boot) SE	<i>p</i> -values	LLCI	ULCI
<i>DV = Person-job fit</i>					
(Constant)	3.8993	0.2920	0.0000	3.3245	4.4741
Gender	−0.1719	0.0852	0.0445	−0.3396	−0.0042
Age	−0.1695	0.0491	0.0006	−0.2661	−0.0729
Educational background	0.0206	0.0452	0.6492	−0.0684	0.1095
Work experience	0.0017	0.0330	0.9580	−0.0632	0.0667
Income	0.1718	0.0396	0.0000	0.0938	0.2497
ACE	−0.1542	0.0584	0.0088	−0.2692	−0.0392
<i>R</i> ²	0.1483				
<i>Adjusted R</i> ²	0.1306				
Model F	8.3879**				
<i>DV = Work engagement</i>					
(Constant)	3.1918	0.7145	0.0000	1.7855	4.5981
Gender	0.0333	0.0511	0.5158	−0.0674	0.1339
Age	−0.0185	0.0303	0.5407	−0.0781	0.0410
Educational background	−0.0278	0.0270	0.3042	−0.0810	0.0254
Work experience	−0.0237	0.0195	0.2262	−0.0620	0.0147
Income	0.0791	0.0242	0.0012	0.0315	0.1266
ACE	−0.6013	0.1873	0.0015	−0.9700	−0.2326
Person-job fit	0.3085	0.0378	0.0000	0.2340	0.3830
CusSt	−0.2173	0.1868	0.2459	−0.5850	0.1505
ACE × CusSt (H9)	0.1542	0.0491	0.0019	0.0576	0.2509
<i>R</i> ²	0.5247				
<i>Adjusted R</i> ²	0.5097				
Model F	35.0750**				
<i>Conditional direct effects of ACE on work engagement</i>					
−1 SD	−0.1190	0.0472	0.0122	−0.2119	−0.0261
Mean	−0.0229	0.0363	0.5274	−0.0943	0.0484
+1 SD	0.0731	0.0476	0.1259	−0.0206	0.1669
<i>Indirect effect of ACE on work engagement</i>					
Person-job fit	−0.0476	0.0204		−0.0891	−0.0084
Note(s): ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$ ACE = ambiguous customer expectation; CusSt = customer stewardship Source(s): Authors' own creation					

Table 4.
Results of moderating
effects of customer
stewardship between
ambiguous customer
expectation and work
engagement

work engagement was significant only at the +1 SD level (coeff = 0.1917, CI = [0.0741, 0.3093]) and person-job fit did not mediate the relationship between customer demandingness and work engagement (coeff = 0.0159, CI = [−0.0235, 0.1033]). Table 5 shows the results of the PROCESS macro model 5 that analyzed the moderating effect of customer stewardship between customer demandingness and work engagement.

To identify the characteristics of statistically significant interaction terms in the results of PROCESS macro procedure, we conducted a simple slope analysis following the procedures proposed by Aiken and West (1991). We identified the conditional influence of an antecedent variable at a single value of the moderating variable through a simple slope analysis. The results showed that the negative influence of ambiguous customer expectations on work engagement was weaker in the high customer stewardship group (gradient of slope = −0.447, $p < 0.01$) than in the low customer stewardship group (gradient of slope = −0.756, $p < 0.01$). Meanwhile, the relationship between customer demandingness and work engagement was significant in the high customer stewardship group (gradient of slope = 0.478, $p < 0.01$), while the low customer stewardship group (gradient of slope = 0.119,

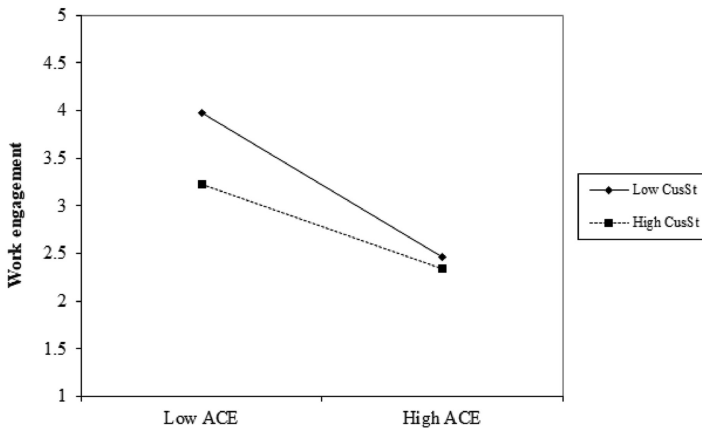
Table 5.
Results of moderating
effects of customer
stewardship between
customer
demandingness and
work engagement

	<i>b</i>	(Boot) SE	<i>p</i> -values	LLCI	ULCI
<i>DV = Person-job fit</i>					
(Constant)	3.1699	0.3098	0.0000	2.5602	3.7796
Gender	−0.2071	0.0862	0.0170	−0.3768	−0.0373
Age	−0.1514	0.0495	0.0024	−0.2488	−0.0541
Educational background	0.0166	0.0457	0.7162	−0.0732	0.1065
Work experience	0.0098	0.0334	0.7683	−0.0559	0.0756
Income	0.1543	0.0406	0.0002	0.0745	0.2341
CusD	0.0913	0.0615	0.0476	0.0010	0.1815
<i>R</i> ²	0.1298				
<i>Adjusted R</i> ²	0.1117				
Model F	7.1824**				
<i>DV = Work engagement</i>					
(Constant)	3.4686	0.7696	0.0000	1.9539	4.9833
Gender	0.0162	0.0510	0.7513	−0.0680	0.1004
Age	−0.0025	0.0299	0.9331	−0.0518	0.0468
Educational background	−0.0314	0.0267	0.2407	−0.0755	0.0127
Work experience	−0.0180	0.0195	0.3566	−0.0501	0.0142
Income	0.0656	0.0242	0.0071	0.0257	0.1055
CusD	0.2985	0.1878	0.0000	0.1879	0.3091
Person-job fit	0.3188	0.0370	0.0000	0.2461	0.3916
CusSt	−0.4093	0.2156	0.0587	−0.8337	0.0151
CusD × CusSt (H9)	0.1797	0.0517	0.0006	0.0780	0.2815
<i>R</i> ²	0.5291				
<i>Adjusted R</i> ²	0.5143				
Model F	35.7086**				
<i>Conditional direct effects of CusD on work engagement</i>					
−1 SD	−0.0323	0.0467	0.4899	−0.1093	−0.0261
Mean	0.0797	0.0429	0.0640	−0.0047	0.1641
+1 SD	0.1917	0.0598	0.0015	0.0741	0.3093
<i>Indirect effect of CusD on work engagement</i>					
Person-job fit	0.0159	0.0208		−0.0235	0.1033
Note(s): ** <i>p</i> < 0.01, * <i>p</i> < 0.05					
ACE = CusD = customer demandingness, CusSt = customer stewardship					
Source(s): Authors' own creation					

p > 0.05) was not significant. Overall, customer stewardship buffers the effect of ambiguous customer expectations on work engagement and increases the effect of customer demandingness on work engagement. Thus, H9 and H10 were supported. The results of the simple slope analysis are shown in Figures 3 and 4.

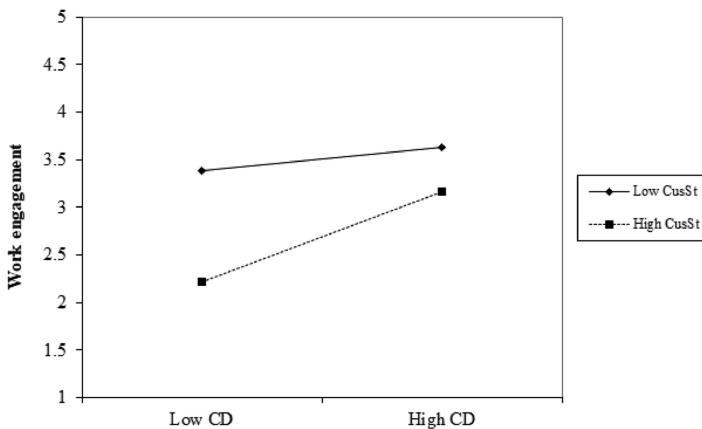
6. Conclusion

We investigated the effects of ambiguous customer expectations and customer demandingness, which reflect hindrance and challenge demands, on BSBs through person-job fit and work engagement and the moderating effect of customer stewardship between job demands and work engagement. As shown in Figure 2, ambiguous customer expectations are negatively related to person-job fit (H1) and work engagement (H2), and customer demandingness is positively linked to person-job fit (H3) and work engagement (H4). Person-job fit enhanced work engagement (H5). We also confirmed that work engagement improved BSBs (H6, H7 and H8). Finally, as shown in Tables 4 and 5, and Figures 3 and 4, we



Source(s): Author's own creation

Figure 3.
Interaction effect of
ambiguous customer
expectation and
customer stewardship



Source(s): Author's own creation

Figure 4.
Interaction effects of
customer
demandingness and
customer stewardship

found that customer stewardship alleviates the negative influence of ambiguous customer expectations on work engagement (H9) while strengthening the positive influence of customer demandingness on work engagement (H10).

6.1 Theoretical implications

We contribute to the marketing literature by presenting customer-related characteristics that influence the BSBs of FBEs and explore psychological response processes. The first contribution of the current study is that ambiguous customer expectations and customer demandingness were specified as customer-related characteristics affecting the BSBs of FBEs. Previous studies have emphasized the importance of frontline employees' BSBs (Bayighomog and Arasli, 2019; Bettencourt and Brown, 2003; Bettencourt *et al.*, 2005), which led scholars to explore antecedents that influence BSBs of frontline employees in services sector. To this end, previous studies have examined the influence of individual-related factors

such as role stressors and personality characteristics (e.g. Bettencourt and Brown, 2003; Chien *et al.*, 2021), or have focused on organizational factors such as relational factors within organization (e.g. Lee and Han, 2020; Yoo, 2013), organizational justice (e.g. Bettencourt *et al.*, 2005) and leadership (e.g. Bayighomog and Arashi, 2019). However, these studies have not confirmed how customer-related characteristics affect BSBs of FBEs. Frontline employees in service sector are expected to interact with customers to identify and satisfy customer needs (Kim and Yoon, 2012; Singh, 2000). In the process, customers increase or inhibit frontline employees' ability to perform their job roles due to individual customer factors (Hüttel *et al.*, 2019). Previous studies have shown that customer-related characteristics affect not only the attitudes of employees related to work but also job behaviors (Stock and Bednarek, 2014; Yoo and Arnold, 2016). Moreover, because banking services are highly customized, customers not only have heterogeneous characteristics from each other (Hüttel *et al.*, 2019), but also typically engage in a high level of interaction with FBEs before being purchased (Chan *et al.*, 2010). Therefore, customer-related characteristics are particularly important to FBEs in the banking services sector. We contribute to the bank marketing literature by identifying the influence of customer-related characteristics on BSBs of FBEs in the banking services sector.

Second, this study presents empirical evidence that ambiguous customer expectations and customer demandingness, which are customer-related job demands, play the role of hindrance and challenge demands, respectively. Previous studies have expanded the JD-R model by identifying that job demands are classified as hindrances and challenges and have different effects on motivation (Crawford *et al.*, 2010; Olafsen and Frølund, 2018; Ventura *et al.*, 2015), whereas attempts to classify customer-related job demands into hindrances and challenges have been deficient. Our results support the notion that ambiguous customer expectations are hindrance demands that inhibit the motivational process of FBEs and play a role in reducing the BSBs of FBEs by negatively affecting cognitive and emotional aspects. In addition, we find support for our findings that customer demandingness is a challenge that enhances the motivational process by positively affecting the cognitive and emotional aspects of FBEs and that it is an antecedent in improving the BSBs of FBEs. The findings of this study expand the theoretical scope of the JD-R model by producing empirical evidence that ambiguous customer expectations belong to hindrance demands and customer demandingness belongs to challenge demands.

Third, our findings provide an understanding of the role of job resources in the relationship between different job demands such as hindrances and/or challenges and work engagement. Previous studies conducted from the JD-R perspective have suggested that job demands and resources are not only negatively associated but also have a buffering effect on each other's psychological processes (Bakker and Demerouti, 2007; Bakker *et al.*, 2014). However, it has been identified that the influence on the motivational process in the extended JD-R model that divides job demands into hindrances and challenges depends on the type of job demands (Van den Broeck *et al.*, 2010; Crawford *et al.*, 2010), and thus the moderating roles of job resources may also be different. We demonstrate that customer stewardship as a job resource buffers the effect of hindrance demands on work engagement and reinforces the effect of challenge demands on work engagement. We enrich the understanding of customer stewardship as a job resource by exploring its role in the relationship between different types of job demands and work engagement.

6.2 Managerial implications

Because our findings indicate that specific factors related to customers affect the BSBs of FBEs, it is necessary to discuss practical strategies to improve their BSBs based on these factors. First, ambiguous customer expectations are negatively related to the psychological aspects of FBEs and diminish BSBs. Therefore, financial service organizations must

establish practical solutions to reduce ambiguous customer expectations. Increasing the social capital between FBEs and customers is one way to lower ambiguous customer expectations. The increase in social capital between FBEs and customers expands shared interpretations and information about each other (Lee and Yoo, 2022; Nahapiet and Ghoshal, 1998). Shared information about customers not only gives FBEs an understanding of the customer's situation, but also allows FBEs to, in reverse fashion, suggest requisitions and/or solutions to customers. Eventually, FBEs' social capital for customers can be utilized as a way to deal with ambiguous customer expectations.

Second, customer demandingness is positively related to the psychological aspects of FBEs and intensifies BSBs. FBEs cannot completely exclude job demands in their job performance, and it is important to identify challenge demands in the jobs of FBEs because challenge demands among job demands are positively related to work engagement. For FBEs to achieve personal development and performance in a job environment with high customer demand, it is necessary to design jobs to increase the empowerment of FBEs. If FBEs are not empowered to respond to customer requests, they cannot address customer demandingness and may lead to increased job stress. Additionally, it is necessary to strengthen their capabilities through regular job training and education, thereby enabling them to meet the level of customer demandingness. Although customer demandingness acts as a training factor that increases the abilities of FBEs (Banin *et al.*, 2016; Jaramillo *et al.*, 2013), FBEs that do not have a certain level of ability cannot handle customer demandingness. Therefore, FBEs that lack job performance capabilities increase job stress because of customer demandingness.

Third, customer stewardship acts as a job resource by buffering the negative influence of hindrance demands on work engagement and improving the positive influence of challenge demands on work engagement. Therefore, practical solutions should be implemented to increase FBEs' customer stewardship. Customer stewardship being reflected in organizational values is a representative solution to improve FBEs' customer stewardship. Organizational values influence the behavior of FBEs and direct them to follow the organization's spirit and philosophy (Boateng *et al.*, 2022). Financial service organizations are required to reflect customer stewardship in organizational values and infuse organizational values into FBEs. For example, financial service organizations can make customer stewardship reflective and prominent in the moral code within the organization, placing it at the forefront of FBEs' minds. Financial service organizations must also infuse in their FBEs a sense of responsibility and ownership in their FBEs. Managers can achieve this by periodically communicating the customer vision of the organization to FBEs.

6.3 Limitations and future research

Our findings represent a framework for investigating the role of customer-related characteristics and their effect on the BSBs of FBEs from the perspective of the JD-R model. Despite these contributions, the current study has several limitations. First, while the JD-R model assumes a psychological dual process (i.e. strain and motivational processes), this study included only the motivational process in the research model. Reflecting on only one of the dual processes in the JD-R model may provide a partial or insufficient understanding of job demands and resources. Therefore, future studies should investigate the role of job demands and resources in the strain process.

Second, we presented customer-related characteristics as antecedents of the BSBs of FBEs. However, despite the existence of various aspects that affect the BSBs of FBEs, we failed to consider other factors. In particular, the characteristics of financial services (e.g. service complexity and degree of contact with customers) were not controlled or considered even though they could affect the degree of relationship with customers. In future studies, an

expansion of the research is required to include various factors that were not considered in the current study.

Third, we conducted our investigation in a single culture (i.e. Asia), which may restrict the generalizability of our results. For example, Korea has a strong collectivistic culture, which may lead to different results from studies conducted in countries with individualistic cultures. Therefore, future studies need to generalize the research findings by examining FBEs belonging to other cultures.

Fourth, this study is not free from endogeneity concerns. [Rutz and Watson \(2019\)](#) emphasized that there is no perfect solution to endogeneity and suggested relying on theory as a way to mitigate endogeneity concerns. In the context of managing endogeneity concerns, researchers may include control variables to address omitted variable bias ([Hill et al., 2021](#)), but it may be implausible to identify and measure all possible control variables. Therefore, researchers should rely on sound theoretical reasoning beyond simply including control variables ([Rutz and Watson, 2019](#)). The purpose of our study is to identify the effects of customer-related characteristics on psychological processes and frontline employees' BSBs in banking services. This study adopted the theoretically extended JD-R model as a framework to understand these objectives and related concepts. All variables set in this study were based on theoretical reasoning. Moreover, [Hill et al. \(2021\)](#) proposed the use of the latent variable method (SEM) and the resolution of the CMV to solve measurement error, which is a source of endogeneity. We utilized covariance-based SEM for analysis and addressed the potential problems of CMV through statistical techniques. Nevertheless, this study cannot be completely free from endogeneity concerns because there is no perfect solution to endogeneity.

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